them said they had come because they were fighting for a dream that was India.

After twenty long years in politics, those initial few weeks reinforced my faith in humanity. I genuinely felt as if politics extended beyond power. What I long felt was a solitary commitment to serve people was suddenly a shared sentiment. Everywhere around me, a huge movement was swirling, engulfing me in its idealism and patriotism. It didn't matter what party you belonged to, which post you held, how much money you had, or which religion or caste you belonged to—everyone was welcome. Everyone who walked (some even hopped in excitedly and walked with us for a while) or witnessed the Yatra from the sides shared a commitment to the nation. In just existing as it did, it was a call to action. It urged us to rise above divisions and be the change we sought. That, I think, was the first big success of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, which put a finger on the pulse of the world's largest democracy. A wide tapestry of voices across the nation melded into a symphony of shared purpose.

The second big success of the Yatra was that it showed the nation and the Congress party that Rahul Gandhi was the one man who people across the country put their unwavering trust in (some doubted him before 2019, as was clear in his resignation letter). If people said this in front of him, one could dismiss it as mere flattery. But they had no reason to tell us that, walking kilometres behind Rahul ji's D-section. Without an iota of exaggeration, I can say that the people I spoke to in every state genuinely saw Rahul Gandhi as someone who would not compromise with the Sangh Parivar. They thought he was sincere, idealistic and with a vision for the country. The nation finally saw his deep sensitivity, which I have witnessed many times.

This was reinforced in Rajasthan, when a man with a disability said to me, 'I may not have legs, but I am here to support Rahul Gandhi in building a better nation.' Despite facing tremendous challenges, he displayed an unwavering commitment to a cause bigger than himself. Obviously his strength went beyond the physical, reminding me to have the courage to